



Elephants and Ethnologists

Read the discredited book claiming that the mesoamerican cultures had exposure to Asian elephants. <https://digit.in/jul20-67>



Bering Strait crossings

A list of approaches that humans have used to cross the Bering strait between Siberia and Alaska. <https://digit.in/jul20-68>

are similarities in the cultures on both sides of the Pacific, and this is a narrow gap that can be crossed in many ways. In fact, even in modern times people have swum across, made the voyage on traditional watercraft, and when it has frozen over, crossed on skis and even walked across.

In 2016, researchers from Purdue University published a very interesting paper. The research showed that metal objects made in Asia had found their way to Alaska through a series of trades. The two objects of interest, a bead and a buckle were dated to between 1100 to 1300 CE, which demonstrates pre-European contact across the Pacific. Metal artefacts are relatively rare, as these objects were typically used till they are completely worn down. It is very likely that the metal was smelted in China, found its way to Siberia, then traded across the Bering Strait.

POLYNESIAN CONTACT

While there is plenty of evidence that there was back and forth contact between the Polynesians and the people of South America. The ancient Austronesians, the people who populate the Pacific islands and who originated from Taiwan, were excellent seafarers. They made epic voyages all the way from Borneo to Madagascar, or from New Zealand to Hawai'i. However, the trip from Easter Island to South America is something of a question mark. We may never know the answer for sure, but if you look at the map of the Austronesian expansion, it is just strange that these seafarers explored all the islands on the Pacific, but did not make the trip to South America.

Linguists have pointed out that the words used for the Sweet Potato, is similar in the Pacific Islands as well as South America. The Sweet Potato itself grows in many Pacific Islands, and is a native plant of South America. There is a theory that the South Americans got the Sweet Potato to the Pacific Islands, or that the Pacific Islanders themselves got the Sweet Potato from South America. There is however a competing

hypothesis, which posits that there was no trade between the South Americans and the Pacific Islanders, and that instead the Sweet Potatoes "drifted" across the Pacific after being dumped by... a merchant vessel. Just like the word for Sweet Potato, on both sides of the Pacific, the local word for "hand axe" have surprising similarities.

The Sweet Potato is not the only telling evidence of contact though. Researchers working with a Peruvian mummy identified the resin of a tree, that was native to Oceania, possibly New Guinea. This resin was responsible for the mummification, on what the



The contentious stele from Copan

scientists initially thought was a natural mummy. The resin was dated to around 1200 CE. There have also been chicken bones found in South America that have been dated to pre-colombian times, with genetic characteristics similar to that of Polynesian chicken. However, the methodology of this particular study has been questioned.

Similar materials, substances and words have been used to trace tenuous contacts between the Chinese, the Japanese and the Mesoamericans as well. There is some evidence that the Mayans grew and used Turmeric dye, a plant that is found only in South Asia. In 1924, Grafton Elliot Smith wrote a book called *Elephants and Ethnologists* where he identified a creature on a Mayan Stele at Copan as an Elephant, a creature found only in Asia at the time it was carved. The

claim was however dismissed, and scientists said that the animal depicted was most certainly a Tapir. While there was plenty of evidence that there could have been contact across the Pacific, the question remained open. One man, Thor Hyderhal set out to prove that such a voyage was possible.

THE KON-TIKI EXPEDITION

The Kon-Tiki was a raft built by the Norwegian explorer Thor Hyderhal, as a demonstration that it was possible to make a crossing of the Pacific from South America to the Polynesian islands, using only the materials and technologies available in pre-colombian America. The main body of the raft was made of balsa wood, with pines, bamboo and mangrove wood used for other parts of the raft. They used sealed bamboo tubes for storing water, and carried coconuts, sweet potatoes, gourds and fruits as their supply of food. They also were prepared for the voyage with a number of fish. A crew of six men made the voyage on this primitive craft, and managed to reach the Tuamotu Islands in French Polynesia, after a voyage lasting 100 days. They had crossed almost 7,000 kilometers in that time. Initially, they landed on an uninhabited island, but locals from another nearby island reached them on canoes and celebrated their arrival. The landmark voyage demonstrated that it was possible for the natives of South America to contact the Polynesian islands, using even the primitive crafts at that time. It is worth noting that the water craft used by Thor Hyderhal was even more primitive than the ones used by the Austronesians during their expansion, it was essentially a raft with sails. The voyage was an attempt to prove Hyderhal's hypothesis that the Easter Islands were colonised by the South Americans. Despite the success of the voyage, contact across the Pacific remains unproven, and is something that we may never find cold, hard evidence for. The voyage of the Kon-Tiki has been excellently recorded in a documentary film of the same name, as well as a book by Hyderhal.